I Challenge You to a Duel

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EXT. ENCHANTED FOREST - DAY

Sir FRANCIS and his SQUIRE are venturing through the forest.

They trudge through a river.

They clamber up a hill.

They play leap-frog.

They stop and eat lunch.

They piggy back ride each other.

Until they find the bridge.

FRANCIS
Squire!

SQUIRE
Sir!

FRANCIS
The map.

Squire pulls out a large, crudely drawn map and unfurls it for both of them to look at. Just beyond the bridge is their destination.

(Alternatively, they pull out the "map" and it's just a drawing of the bridge in front of them)

FRANCIS
Excellent! Onward!

SQUIRE
Onward sir!

JOM
(off-screen)
HAAAAAAAALT!

Francis and Squire stop in their tracks as they turn and see a knight, JOM, stepping out from behind a tree. He is adorned in fancy armor and wielding a sword.

JOM
(cont'd)
Who goes there?

Squire pathetically toots a horn.

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SQUIRE
May I present Sir Francis of Worcestershire on his noble quest to find Lord Quembley of Frankfurt and convince him to align with the Worcestershirian Forces - and I am his humble Squire, G-

FRANCIS
(interrupting)
And who are you, fellow knight?

JOM
I am a protector of the realm, instructed by Gulliver the Unready the Third to keep post in these woods and to guard...

Jom steps in front of the bridge, blocking it.

JOM
(cont'd)
this bridge. I am called Jom.

FRANCIS
Jom?

JOM
That's my name...don't wear it out.

Francis and Squire look at each other confused.

FRANCIS
I see. Surely you can let us pass though, seeing as our quest has no cross with you or your lord Gulliver.

JOM
That is "Gulliver the Unready the Third" to you, and he is no lord, he is something higher. A philosopher. A rather intelligent and persuasive man I met by a pond some years ago feeding bread to ducks and feeding those ducks to some very large fish. And no sir I am afraid I cannot.

FRANCIS
I'm sorry if I've offended but I'm afraid that I cannot accept that answer.

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JOM
No?

FRANCIS
No.

JOM
Then, Sir Francis, I challenge you to a duel!

FRANCIS
I would prefer not to engage in violence. But if it's blood you must have then blood you shall. Squire!

SQUIRE
Sir!

Squire runs down to Francis and presents him his sword. Francis picks it up and readies himself.

FRANCIS
To first blood?

JOM
To the death.

FRANCIS
I see. The best of luck to you.

JOM
And none to you.

As the swords raise and are about to clash, another voice interrupts:

BETWEEN THE RAISED SWORDS WE SEE: PIERRE

PIERRE
HO THERE!

Francis and Jom pause and lower their swords.

JOM AND FRANCIS
Ho there!

Pierre waddles down the hill with a sword on his hip.

PIERRE
I am Sir Pierre Lavost of the Longmire and I am here to cross that bridge. I

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have business with Lord Guinness.

JOM
I am Jom of the bridge and I say nay.

PIERRE
"Nay" you say?

JOM
Yes.

FRANCIS
He insists you must duel him to the death if you are to cross.

PIERRE
A duel? To the death?

JOM
It must be so.

PIERRE
Then so be it!

All the men yell and raise their swords again ready to fight. Then are suddenly interrupted by a wandering traveler a little ways off and approaching:

NORMAN
Hello there!

Francis groans, Jom and Pierre turn to see NORMAN.

PIERRE AND JOM
Hello!

Norman approaches carrying a large pack.

NORMAN
You gentlemen look busy. Could I interest any of you in any trinkets or treats? A necklace or two? A bracelet? Perhaps a bit of bread? A bit of delicious week-old bread?

FRANCIS
No, thank you.

PIERRE
How much is the bread?

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NORMAN
5 gold?

PIERRE
God, no, I don't have that on me.

NORMAN
Terrible shame. Then I must be off to continue my business!

JOM
Not if I have anything to say about it!

Pierre and Francis talk over each other trying to explain the situation.

FRANCIS
You go.

PIERRE
You need to fight this knight -

JOM
Jom!

PIERRE
Jom, thank you...to the death, if we're to pass.

Beat.

NORMAN
Shame. I'd like one business trip where I didn't have to take another mans life.

Norman pulls out a frying pan.

FRANCIS
A pan?

NORMAN
I promise you, lad, this pan has taken more lives than that sword in your hands.

Francis and the others look at each other worried.

JOM
To the death!

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They all prepare to fight again until they are yet again interrupted by a duo of ladies walking their way.

ELIZABETH
Pardon us gentlemen, could you hold off on your...grand free for all, until we pass?

ROSE
It'll only take a moment.

The group of men look at each other wondering who's turn it is to explain the situation.

NORMAN
I believe we need to fight this gentleman here to the death if we're to cross the bridge.

JOM
I am Jom of the bridge!

ELIZABETH
Yes, hello Jom. I am Elizabeth.

ROSE
And I'm Rose, we waved hello when we were first coming this way from town.

FRANCIS
You came from the town across the bridge?

ELIZABETH
Yes. While Jom is a terrific guard he can be quite troublesome.

JOM
Thank you.

ROSE
Can you let us through please? We must get home.

JOM
I'm afraid I can't allow that. On different circumstances I may have allowed it, but with a crowd there is a problem. If I let one in I have to let everyone in.

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FRANCIS
I really don't mind, you can let them in.

NORMAN
I don't either, I've killed before I'm ok killing again.

FRANCIS
Stop.

PIERRE
I'd be a bit upset.

JOM
See? No special treatment.

ELIZABETH
I see. So be it.

Elizabeth and Rose quickly pull out sharp daggers and aim them at the men, ready to kill all of them.

The men jump back, startled.

JOM
Now then...to the death?

FRANCIS
To the death.

STRANGER
(from a distance)
Hello!

FRANCIS
Christ! Squire!

Squire picks up a rock and throws it at the STRANGER. The stranger in the distance falls to the ground unconscious.

PIERRE
Enough interruptions!

They all yell and jump into a fray with each other. Swords, pans, and daggers clash - all except for Francis and his squire.

Francis and Squire look on at the battle disappointed and exhausted - then to the bridge, unguarded with Jom preoccupied.

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SQUIRE
Onward, sir?

FRANCIS
Onward.

Francis and Squire walk across the bridge as the rest fight to the death.

the END.